

Politics of Poverty

A penniless politician may not be an idea the electorate can familiarise itself with too easily. But Bhagwant Singh Samao, the 29-year-old CPI(M) Liberation candidate from Bhatinda, is an exception. He has no home, car, cash, bank balance, land, moveable or immovable property. Add to this an outstanding bank loan of Rs 15,000. So how does he survive? "I fight for the *mazdoors*. And those I fight for take care of my food and other needs. Also, I live in my party office," he says unabashedly.

by Arvind Chhabra

SAMAO



KRISHNA MURARI KISHAN



SHANTI PRIYA AND PAPPU YADAV

Seventh Wonder

Women and politicians rarely turn too old. The affidavit of convicted MP Pappu Yadav's mother, Shanti Priya, maintains that she is 49. Shanti Priya is contesting the Lok Sabha election from Bihar's Purnia constituency as a Congress-supported independent candidate. On the other hand, Yadav, who had contested from the same seat in 2004, had then mentioned that he was 37. This should make him 42 in 2009, which in turn implies that his mother was only seven years of age when he was born. The 'gaffe' has come to light now, as the district administration's scrutiny of her nomination papers failed to find out the error. Incidentally, Yadav put up his mother as a candidate in the elections following his conviction in a murder case. by Amitabh Srivastava

18 of the 20 constituencies in Kerala that went to polls during the first round on April 16 saw more women voters than men.

Ad Vantage Point

Advertising campaigns by political parties seem to be inviting trouble for them. Recently, a supporter of BSP national general secretary Akhilesh Das lodged an FIR against eight local Urdu dailies for publishing ads that endorse the SP. The BSP finds these ads 'undignified'. The ads which equate the BSP with the BJP say that while one party objects to Muslims wearing caps and sporting beards, Mayawati has objections to *namaaz*. The FIR comes at a time when Mayawati is desperately trying to woo Muslims. by Farzand Ahmed

MANEESH AGNIHOTRI



MAYAWATI AND DAS

BATTLE Royale

Banking on Maharajas has been a common indulgence for political parties, and going by the look of things, the upcoming polls don't seem to be any different. Out of 25 candidates, Congress has picked up a few hailing from royal families. Leading the pack is Chandresh Kumari, sister of Jodhpur Maharaja Gaj Singh, who will be contesting elections from Jodhpur. In Alwar, it has opted for two-time MLA Jitendra Singh, who is

JITENDRA SINGH



PURUSHOTTAM DIWAKAR

believed to be close to Rahul Gandhi. Prince Ijyaraj Singh, 44, an MBA from Columbia Business School, will foray into politics as he fights for the Kota seat. The BJP is also catching up on the race. It has fielded sitting MLA Rao Rajendra Singh from Jaipur (rural), while incumbent V.P. Singh has also been retained to contest from the Bhilwara seat. If this wasn't enough, Vasundhara Raje's son and sitting MP Dushyant Singh, heir to Dholpur's Jat royalty, will be fighting to retain the Jhalawar seat. by Rohit Parihar